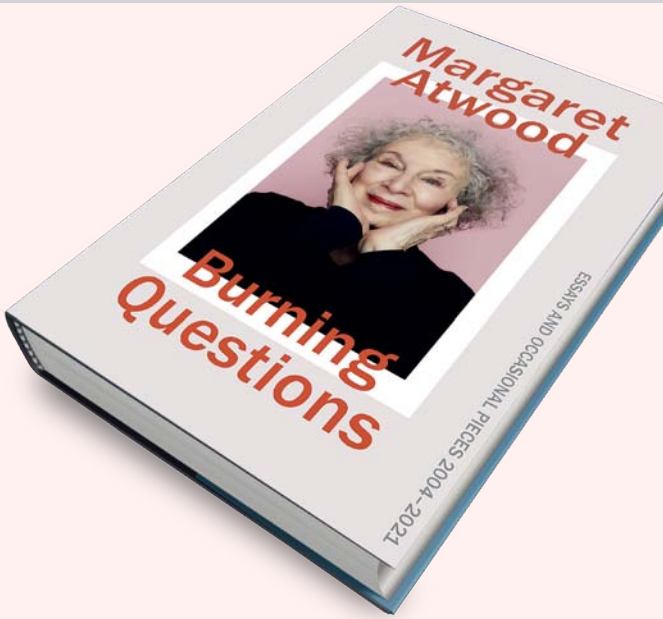
BOOKS

Making Everything Illuminated

ANN PATCHETT AND MARGARET ATWOOD BARE THEMSELVES IN THEIR NEW ESSAY COLLECTIONS, BUT MORE CRUCIALLY, THEY MAKE THE WORLD A MORE SCRUTABLE PLACE



BURNING QUESTIONS: ESSAYS AND OCCASIONAL PIECES 2004-2021
by Margaret Atwood
CHATTO AND WINDUS
₹999; 496 pages

Essays published over years of a writer's career reflect the ideas and explorations of a lifetime. When we try to discern a pattern in those compiled in a particular volume, we are like the stargazer who fashions 11 points of light in the night sky into a hunter carrying a dagger, followed by a dog. *These Precious Days* by Ann Patchett starts with "Three Fathers", in which she describes the varying roles played by her own father and her two stepfathers in her life, and what each supplied in terms of acceptance, experience and learning. The book ends with a poignant but unsentimental essay on the lingering death of her biological father.

That may have been a deliberate pattern, or not. A more entertaining way to look at this writer's shimmering essays is to compare them, as she has, to a series of snapshots taken when she is wearing a sleeveless gown, then a miniskirt, then a

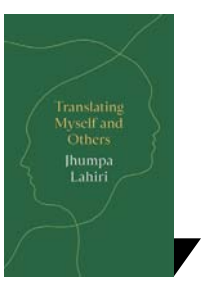


ATWOOD'S WRITING HAS PROVED TO BE SO PRESCIENT–ABOUT CLIMATE CHANGE, THE PANDEMIC–THAT SHE SEEMS OBLIGED TO DENY SHE OWNS A CRYSTAL BALL

ON THE SAME PAGE

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by Jhumpa Lahiri
PRINCETON UNIVERSITY PRESS
₹599; 208 pages



Few authors write in two languages, and even fewer manage to do it with the kind of assurance that Lahiri does. In this collection, the Pulitzer winner reflects on why she writes and translates from Italian.

